THE CANON OF THE NEW TESTAMENT

Can we talk of a single canon for the New Testament? The answer is a big No. History has revealed to us the existence of many other canons other than the one we are familiar with. There are for example the existence of Marcion, Muratorian and the one accepted by Eusebius. Is it categorical that there is such thing as a universally accepted canon i.e., be it for the New Testament or the Old Testament?

Many Christians assume that the 27 documents in the New Testament are accepted over board. Luther rejected two of this collection among them Revelation and Jude. He maintains that these documents contain the Catholic doctrine of purgatory hence they cannot be inspired. The Orthodox for their part they have additional eight documents in this collection. An example of such inclusion are the Letters of Clement.

There are two basic considerations for the acceptance of these documents into the canon.

The criteria for the New Testament:-

1. Apostolic Linkage: The document must have a link with an apostle. The Gospel of Luke is linked to Paul, Mathew to Levi the tax collector, Mark to Peter and John to the beloved disciple.
2. Ecclesial linkage: The Church must have considered it as useful for its teaching on faith. It explains why a Gospel like Thomas was rejected because of it's over emphasis on the humanity of Jesus. The Church has always taught that Jesus was both human and divine. The other aspect is that the document must have been written early on. Late documents were not accepted.

Transmission and Translations of the Bible: Old Testament

The question the readers of the Bible often ask is, which one is the best Bible? This is a complex question because we need to understand the purpose of the reader. People may read the Bible for either spiritual nourishment or for academic endeavor. A reader may therefore require a different version to use.

A keen reading of the Bible points to alternative readings in some texts (Mk 1:1 ;16:8). This is evidence that there existed differing manuscripts. A Bible with textual notes at the end of the text testify to the existence of these variant readings.

The process that has given us the biblical text that we have received is a long one. Transmission began when the oral words were finally put into writing. There are three languages were basically used: Hebrew, Greek and Aramaic. Much of the original text of the Old Testament was written in Hebrew. We too have books that were original written in Greek what we have referred to as apocryphal writings or Deuterocanonical books. There is evidence that Aramaic was also used in texts like Daniel. The New Testament was wholly a Greek text though there are debates whether the gospel of Mathew was originally composed in Hebrew, Aramaic or Greek?

Understanding of the transmission of the Bible will help the reader avoid some fundamentalism about the text. The reader, for example, will understand that the text has changed over time as the text was copied out. It will open up the reader to read wholly and critically. The reader will pay attention to textual apparatus.

Beginners in the studies of the Bible think that the Bible they posses come from the original manuscript, which is not the case. The original manuscripts are lost and our Bible emanate from late manuscripts. This is very understandable because the Palestinian climate was not conducive for the preservation of the materials like papyrus and leather on which the writing was done for such a long time.

The primary text used in formal study of the Old Testament is the so called Massoretic text (MT) which dates from the 2nd century CE. Massoretic text is called so because the text owes it origin from a group of writers know as the Massoretes. The word is derived from the Hebrew word Massora which means tradition or transmission.

The original Hebrew text was a consonantal text or unprinted text. It was written with vowels. It is a difficult text to read and pronounce. The reading was done from memory. Hence with the increasing need for new texts there were distortions in the subsequent texts. Therefore, there arose a need to stabilize the text.

This need promoted the Massoretes to introduce the vowel points in the Hebrew text. The Massoretic text is therefore a text with vowels. The function of the Massoretes consisted of the following:

- Establishing an authentic consonantal text because there were already many variants of texts in circulation
- Supplying the consonantal text with vowel points and accents
- Added hand written commentaries on the side columns and at the ending of each book

We credit these people with the stabilization of the Hebrew Bible. The way we read the Hebrew Bible today stems from the Massoretes.

The existing old manuscripts of the MT are the Codex Lenigradensis (L) dating about 1009 CE. The codex L contains the whole of the Old Testament. This codex is today found in Russia in St. Petersburg. The other manuscript is Codex Allepo

(A). It includes everything except the Pentateuch. The codex is kept in Jerusalem. These two texts represent the received text of Massoretic texts. The Old Testament that we read is based on the MT. It is regarded as the standard text.

There are, however, two other Hebrew texts that we can study to shed light to this generally acknowledged standard text. These texts include the Dead Sea scrolls/Qumran documents and the Samaritan Pentateuch.

The Samaritan Pentateuch (Sam P) contains the sacred scriptures of the Samaritans – a sect dating from the second temple period (i.e. 500 BC to 100 CE) which split from Judaism. The Sam P dates about 2nd – 1st Century BCE. There are a number of Sam P variants that contains older and more original readings than the MT. The Sam P bears special characteristics. Large number of variants is brought about by harmonization or revision of texts to make them run smoothly.

In Ex 14:11-12 for example the MT mentions a protest which does not appear in Sam P. Sam P adds something about the Israelite complaining to Moses in Ex 6:9 to make the reading smooth.

The Qumran documents: the excavation of the caves of Qumran, i.e., a location near the Dead Sea in Massada in 1947 yielded a textual witness in form of the Qumran documents.

The Qumran documents have both fragments and complete roll of almost all the biblical books. Most fragments date from 1st Century BCE – 1st Century CE. The importance of these fragments is two fold:

- It is a more closer to the original texts;

- It indicates that a multiplicity of texts existed in the century before the common era.

The presence of these other textual witnesses leads us to conclude that the MT is simply one witness of a textual form which was around in the 4th - 3rd century BCE.

Non Hebrew Textual Forms

A number of other ancients texts that are useful in tracing the origin of variant readings which differ from MT are in translations. These ancient translations are known as versions. The most important ones are; Septuagint (LXX); Syriac translation); Targum (Aramaic translation) Vulgate (Latin translation).

The Septuagint (LXX) it is the most important translation of the Hebrew Bible. The myth that surrounds it is that 72 Jewish scholars were responsible for its translation. There are suggestions that the place was in Alexandria in Egypt. The translation was done at different periods from 3rd to 1st century BCE.

Syriac translation: this is a translation from Hebrew to Syriac language. It dates from the 2nd century CE. The translation differs from LXX.

Targum translation: this is a translation from Hebrew to Aramaic for Jews who were in Palestine and Babylon from the end of the 6th century BCE onwards. Targum usually follows the MT but there are variations between the two.

Vulgate: it is the Latin translation from Hebrew. Vulgate is a unique translation since it is a one man translation. Jerome translated it between 390-406 CE. It is not a perfect translation since it has Christian orientation. Prior to it

the Christians in North Africa had used Vetus Latina – a translation form 2nd – 3rd century CE based on the text of the LXX.

The importance of this discussion is helping one understand the nature of the text we are reading. At certain points in the text of the Bible we find letters like a, b and so. These letters are explained at the end of the text. The understanding of these notes safeguards us against fundamentalism in biblical studies. A good standard Bible suffices to illustrate what we have discussed here.

The Transmission of the New Testament

The original New Testament Greek text was written in capital letters without spacing. It is known as the **uncials**. The upper and lower cases came only later and that is the **minuscules**. Eventually, copying of the New Testament produced textual variants. It is estimated that over 2500 textual witnesses exist for the New Testament. These texts often do not agree. These texts are grouped into three text types. Texts fall into types owing to nature of how they were copied. As far as we can tell, most or all of the earliest copies were done in what is called a free style. People copied liberally, perhaps correcting what they saw as mistakes,and even adding comments in the appear to fall Into the third category of strict copies. Strict copies,like their name suggests,have little copying would become more common as time passed. copying freely and then more

strictly tended to produce local variations in the text. Each text types preserves certain variants in the text,and as even more time passed.

In contrast to the Old Testament where we have a representative for the whole text, the New Testament is made from many different manuscripts. The Old Testament is therefore rightly referred to as a diplomatic text and the New Testament as the eclectic text.